

El Monte



Commandery
No. 2



Knights Templar of Utah

Dork Rite Bodies of Ogden

Sir Knights, Friends, Family, Honored Guests,

May the God of love and peace delight to dwell with and bless each of you. In this, the Year of Prayer, let it remind each of us to be filled in the spirit and renew our faith, rededicate our commitments, reaffirm our purpose, and restore each of us, in obedience to the commandments of Christ Jesus. We read in the Gospel According to Saint Matthew Chapter 16 verse 24 “Then said Jesus unto his disciples, If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross, and follow me.” - (King James Version) – Christ invites us to draw closer to God and live as He chose to live, not in the world – but as Paul wrote in his First Epistle to the Corinthians – “...Do all [things] to the Glory of God.” Christ sums up this purpose with his admonishment explaining that “For the Son of man shall come in the glory of his Father with his angels; and then he shall reward every man according to his works.” - (the Gospel According to Saint Matthew Chapter 16 verse 27 - King James Version)

The very act of being Christian, much like being a Freemason, and a Knight Templar – is a call to action. It is a reminder to act uprightly, squarely, virtuously, and above all – compassionately. We are charged with the privilege that “Every human being has a claim upon your [our] kind offices...” and that we must “do good unto all.”

No, we are not perfect. Nor should we lead ourselves to the arrogance, pride, or vainglory of assuming an ego – or an air of superiority towards anyone. For as Jesus instructs us, “But he that is greatest among you shall be your servant. And whosoever shall exalt himself shall be abased; and he that shall humble himself shall be exalted.” - (the Gospel According to Saint Matthew Chapter 23 verses 11 & 12 - King James Version) It is this call to action, this call to serve our fellow man in humility and meekness, with love and compassion that

Christ demands of us when he invites each of us to deny ourself. We are asked to consider the needs of others, and if possible, help them with their needs; to give what we can, out of our abundance, in order to lift up others and improve their life. Even a small measure of compassion and understanding can restore a person's life.

We must never allow the unattainable state of perfection to deter us from the path of righteousness. For like the pilgrim – it is never about the destination, it is the transformative journey to separates and defines who we are as men and Masons. We poor frail and imperfect mortals – will make mistakes; we will discover our own failings, and shortcomings; we will fall from grace.

At times, throughout my own, personal journey, it seemed as though I made it my daily goal - to rush out and make the biggest mistakes that any man could make. Lord truly knows that I am not even remotely close to perfect; but, by the Grace of God, the love and patience of the Craft, and the faith of every Sir Knight, I have been restored and granted the chance to resume my journey.

As the architects of our respective personal journeys, we must follow the examples set before us. Christ Jesus instructs us - “But thou, when thou prayest, enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.” - (the Gospel According to Saint Matthew Chapter 6 verse 6 - King James Version) Here Jesus teaches us to remove ourselves from the distractions of life, to go into our inner sanctuary, and pray for the guidance or wisdom to plan our path; or, draw the designs upon our trestleboard.

How often should we pray? In the Book Colossians chapter 4 verse 2 we read: “Continue in prayer, and watch in the same with thanksgiving;” – (King James Version) Our prayers should be constant and filled with gratitude for every aspect of this life. As long as we can experience this life, we should emulate Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, walking away from Nebuchadnezzar II's fiery furnace – just saved by God, and blessing everything that is seen and unseen in praise of God the Father; knowing that every aspect of life is a blessing. Whether we know it to be so, or not.

Christ did not become the paschal Lamb of God - so that we may take for granted the abundance of Love and compassion He has shown us. Nor were we asked to mourn His sacrifice, or this Life we are blessed with. Christ's heart sang Psalms 23 loudly in His every action.

This Easter we are called to follow our Lord and Savior – who shepherds each of us through this Life. We are called to prayer, and renewed in the Ministry of Love and Compassion - Christ truly has fulfilled the Prophet Ezekiel's words who said: “A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh.” - (the Book of Ezekiel Chapter 36 Verse 26 King James Version) – Christ Jesus has conquered that great leveler of man – and risen to

give us a new heart, a new spirit, and a new life. Let us share the gospel through our actions.

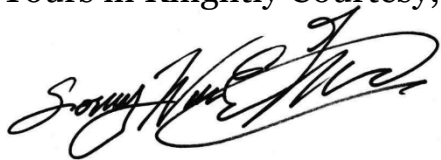
As Christians, let us humbly, contritely, and compassionately live according to the commandments of Christ - renewed in the faith of His promises; redeemed in His blessed sacrifice; rededicated to the Ministry of Love and Compassion toward every human being; Reaffirmed in the purposes of our pilgrim's journey; Restored in our call to act as Christians, as men, as Masons, as Knights Templar in the service of Christ Jesus – our Lord and Saviour.

We must pray and pray often. May we thank God for every moment we experience in this life. May we pray for peace, for strength, for guidance, and for wisdom. May we pray to be given a new heart filled in the spirit each day. May that spirit fill our hearts in abundance until our cup runneth over. May we share our surplus with those in need.

As often as we pray, let those words not remain idle. Let those words become actions. In every thing we do, let every action Glorify our Father who is in Heaven. In doing this, the world will know God the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. As Knights in the Service of Christ – The world will judge all that we represent in what we do, and how we make them feel.

May your actions restore society's faith in all that we represent. And May almighty God continue to bless each of you and your loved ones.

Yours in Knightly Courtesy,



Sir Knight William E. McCraw, EC
Eminent Commander
El Monte Commandery No. 2, KT of Utah

